Active Blended Learning

About This Guide

This guide is designed for LJMU staff to help them implement effective active blended learning approaches. It offers practical principles, recommendations, and strategies that can be adapted to various disciplinary contexts and institutional environments.

The guide begins by examining blended learning and active learning as distinct educational approaches before exploring how they can be integrated to create powerful learning experiences that maximise student engagement and achievement.

Understanding the Key Concepts

Blended Learning

Blended learning combines face-to-face and online instruction where students interact with their teacher(s), fellow students, and relevant learning materials across different environments. This approach offers flexibility in curriculum delivery while maintaining educational quality and student engagement. At its core, blended learning is about thoughtfully integrating online and in-person experiences to leverage the strengths of each modality.

Active Learning

Active learning is an approach to instruction that engages students in the learning process through activities, discussion, problem-solving, and reflection rather than passively receiving information. It emphasises higher-order thinking and often involves collaborative work. Active learning strategies encourage students to be participants in knowledge construction rather than mere recipients of content.

The Integration: Active Blended Learning

Active blended learning brings together concepts from learning theory and technology. It enhances student learning by structuring and capturing their time-on-task, as well as involving them in complex collective and individual problem solving. Technology can support this both in physical and online learning spaces. This, in turn, assists tutors by capturing student progress through formative tasks.

Learning can be characterised by students having both cognitive and social presence in the learning environment. Cognitive presence reflects critical thinking, problem solving, and construction of meaning in students' interactions with peers and tutors. Social presence is the extent to which students are 'connected' during that.

Active blended learning is a process of constructing the curriculum through identifying the aspects that are best delivered through face-to-face teaching and those that can be delivered online. It gives equal priority to signaling to students that they learn both within the class and outside of it.

Principles for active blended learning

1. Recognise learning as a social, as well as an individual intellectual activity.
2. Reinforce connections between students and staff.
3. Create a sense of belonging.
4. Maximise opportunities for engagement, participation and interaction in both physical and online learning spaces.
5. Recognise and support digital capability of both staff and students as a key component to the success of online/blended learning
6. Provide online learning materials that are accessible for all
7. Provide intellectually robust and challenging learning materials and activities that prepare for, motivate to and consolidate learning.
8. Explicitly scaffold learning activities to indicate expectation and support student management of their own learning.
9. Provide a range of materials and methods for students to engage with.
10. Effectively use data and learning analytics to identify student engagement.

The function of online learning and teaching

Active blended learning retains some conventional uses of the VLE within an enhanced functionality. This includes:

Curation of high quality, independent learning resources, including:

- Conventional 'broadcast' materials such as Panopto videos
- Documents including presentations and supplementary notes
- Links to relevant readings and external sources of information
- Suitable external learning resources

'Live' teaching that allows structured participation in real-time

Provision of interactive activities, including:

- Quizzes
- Blogs/Wikis
- Discussion forums
- Discussion/chat with other students and tutors in real-time
- Answering tutor's questions
- Voting /polling
- Shared documents
- Submitting short 'low stakes' work for quick feedback
- Journaling

Sense-making activities that help students to understand and consolidate learning. This includes opportunities for reflection, debate and testing ideas

Key Factors

It is important that tutors remain highly visible in learning spaces.

- Synchronously through opportunities for real-time engagement
- Asynchonously through regular communication, discussion boards etc.

Students need clear direction to manage online learning. This should include:

- Explicit articulation of the relationship between online and physical engagement.
- Expectations of appropriate behaviour
- Details of anticipated time on task for activities
- A detailed structure of the anticipated learning process

Face-to-face teaching

It is anticipated that scheduled physical classes will constitute a fraction of the normal timetable. Therefore, these should be used as opportunities to reinforce social presence and experiences that generate a sense of belonging. They should:

- Eschew conventional didactic teaching
- Explicitly build upon and reinforce learning in the online environment
- Emphasise activities that promote student-to-student interaction
- Maximise reflection, debate and challenge.
- Provide opportunities for students to check understanding of online learning

Recommendations

Curriculum design

Curricula that have been designed primarily for face-to-face teaching that is supplemented by online activity may need review. A characteristic of such curricula is the online activity tends to focus on self-directed study with relatively minimal supervision. This cannot be the case in blended learning models that rely on significant levels of online delivery. This may prompt a need to review curriculum structure, anticipated delivery, some content and assessment

1. That necessary changes can be made to programme structure and delivery to facilitate online learning and engagement. It is important that these changes don't compromise programme standards, but the process needs to be simple and quick to support the development of online provision.
2. That programme teams explore options for a different volume/patterns of face-to-face delivery for different levels of study. This would allow for more flexible provision of support to reflect need.
3. That engagement activities reflect the needs associated with level of study
4. That programme teams consider reviewing delivery patterns to maximise opportunities for online learning and assessment. This may signal, for example, a shift from parallel delivery to series delivery or the adoption of a hybrid model.
5. That all curricula frontload instruction and support for online learning to facilitate student engagement in the process from the outset.

Teaching, learning and assessment activities

Blended learning will necessitate a shift in academic practice. Online learning opportunities will have to include more opportunities for interaction. In addition, programme teams need to maximise the value of face-to-face teaching to reinforce learning as opposed to presenting information. Sharing resources and using external materials will help to reduce the burden on academic staff, whilst maintaining a high standard of learning opportunity

1. That all live online teaching is recorded to accommodate students' needs during the period of disruption.
2. That the Academy supports the development of shared learning materials by working with both academic and professional services teams (eg 'Skills@LJMU, Student Engagement Team, Student Advancement)
3. That the use of Canvas Commons is promoted to facilitate resource sharing.
4. That programme teams consider 'decoupling' face-to-face teaching sessions from module delivery. These sessions would then act as opportunities for cross-module students to discussion their learning across modules in the form of 'Peer Learning Groups' or seminars.
5. That all online resources meet accessibility standards.

Student support

Face-to-face teaching is characterised by both formal and informal guidance, instruction and support. The nature of online provision is that this will need to be formalised and structured to a greater degree than would traditionally be the case.

1. That students are provided with clear instructions regarding how to engage in specific modules and individual teaching sessions.
2. That programme teams consider the use of module templates to afford a degree of consistency across modules.
3. That module leaders use Canvas Pages to help students conceptualise and inter-relate the learning resources associated with specific sessions.
4. That academic staff use Canvas Analytics to both identify struggling students and provide evidence of what works in online delivery.

Student voice

The University has varied formal mechanisms for capturing the student voice. Some of these (e.g. surveys) are inherently online, other forms need adaptation to work in an online environment. In addition, it is recognised that much feedback is informal. This occurs through impromptu conversations after lectures, in meetings, coffee shops and corridors. These also need to be facilitated in the online environment

1. That programme teams offer opportunities outside the modular structure for students to engage with staff through group chat, regular polling or online meetings.